

The Prescott Girls — Discussion Questions (Students)

Leaving New Sharon

Chapters 1–2: Sandy River; Leaving New Sharon

The story begins with loss and uncertainty as the family prepares to leave the only home the girls have known.

Questions:

1. What specific moment or image best shows what the Prescott family is leaving behind?
 2. How does each girl respond differently to their father's death and the move? Give one example for each.
 3. What does "home" mean to the girls at this point in the story? What details support your answer?
 4. What specific concern or question does one of the girls express about what comes next?
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The Road to Dresden

Chapters 3–4: The Long Road; The Wheel and the Hill

As the family travels, each girl responds differently to discomfort, danger, and the unknown ahead.

Questions:

1. What details show what the journey is like for the family?
 2. How are the girls adjusting emotionally as they travel?
 3. What do the girls' questions reveal about what they are wondering or worried about?
 4. What moment shows that something is wrong with the wagon?
 5. How is the danger of the wheel discovered and handled?
 6. What is the first impression of the courthouse when the girls arrive?
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Entering a New World

Chapters 5–8: The Pownalborough Court House; Sallie and the Old Fort; The Locked Cabinet; A Place to Call Home

The girls enter an unfamiliar space and begin to understand what it means to live there.

Questions:

1. What are the girls' first impressions of the courthouse?
 2. What details show that the house begins to feel less strange over time?
 3. How does Sallie begin to feel at home in a different way from her sisters?
 4. What do the girls learn about the history of the courthouse and the land around it?
 5. What does Beckie discover in the locked cabinet, and why is it important?
 6. What helps Louisa begin to feel at home?
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Work, Study, and New Ideas

Chapters 9–12: Stitches Before the Sunset; A Letter from Philadelphia; The Sugar Question; The Unexpected Guest

Daily routines begin to form, and new ideas from beyond Maine begin to influence the girls' thinking.

Questions:

1. What shows that Beckie is taking her sampler work seriously?
 2. How are the three girls learning and growing in different ways?
 3. Why is the letter from Philadelphia important?
 4. What new ideas does Hannah introduce?
 5. How do the girls begin to think differently after hearing these ideas?
 6. What decision do the girls make about sugar, and what does it reveal about them?
 7. How does Mrs. Price's visit deepen their understanding of courage and action?
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Speaking and Being Heard

Chapters 13–17: Voices Raised; Three Letters to Philadelphia; The Sermon; The Tavern Below; A Visitor from Vassalboro

The girls begin to express their ideas, and their voices enter into a wider conversation.

Questions:

1. What moment shows Beckie deciding to speak?
2. How do the girls' voices differ when they speak?
3. How do others respond to what the girls say?
4. What shows that their words are shared beyond that moment?
5. What happens when they are asked to speak again in front of others?
6. What evidence shows that not everyone agrees with them?

7. How do their ideas begin to spread beyond their town?
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Community, Custom, and Conviction

Chapters 18–20: Apple Day; A Quaker Wedding; News from Philadelphia

The girls observe how values are lived out in their community and begin to form their own convictions.

Questions:

1. How does shared work bring the community together?
 2. How do the girls begin to connect daily work to larger ideas about responsibility?
 3. What does Beckie begin to understand about how change happens?
 4. What differences do the girls notice in the Quaker wedding?
 5. What values are shown in the wedding ceremony?
 6. What do the girls begin to imagine about their own futures?
 7. What new ideas or questions come from Hannah's letter?
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Secrets, School, and Conscience

Chapters 21–24: Louisa's Secret; At the School House; The Classroom Reckoning; The Ribbon and the Loom

Private struggles and public discussions bring questions of fairness and responsibility into sharper focus.

Questions:

1. What does Louisa discover in the attic, and why does it trouble her?
 2. What does Uncle Thomas help her understand about the past?
 3. Why does Louisa choose to keep the secret at first?
 4. What questions do the girls raise at school about trade and slavery?
 5. How do they present their ideas to others?
 6. How does Louisa reveal the truth, and what does she learn from doing so?
 7. How do the girls begin to live out their beliefs in everyday choices?
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Winter, Memory, and Endurance

Chapters 25–29: A Letter from Father; Company for the Holidays; Christmas Day; Winter Market; The Nor'easter

The family faces hardship and reflection during the winter months, drawing strength from memory and community.

Questions:

1. What does the letter from their father reveal?
 2. How does the family respond emotionally to the letter?
 3. What shows how family and community bring warmth during winter?
 4. How do the girls experience both joy and loss during Christmas?
 5. What do they learn about work and responsibility at the winter market?
 6. What choice does Beckie make at the market, and why?
 7. What does the storm reveal about endurance and community?
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Memory, Loss, and Continuity

Chapter 30: Packing Winter Away

The girls reflect on their father's memory and begin to understand how loss can become part of who they are.

Questions:

1. What details show the changing season and mood?
 2. How does Sallie's search for matching items reflect how she sees the world?
 3. What brings their father's memory into the moment?
 4. How do the girls remember their father differently?
 5. What do they learn about how he lived and what he valued?
 6. What do they understand about how he died?
 7. How do they begin to carry his memory forward?
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Return and Belonging

Chapters 31–33: A Visit from Hannah; The Gathering; Family Ties

Relationships reconnect and deepen, bringing the story to a quiet but meaningful resolution.

Questions:

1. How does Hannah's return show both change and continuity?
2. What does she help the girls understand about living out values?
3. What confirms that speaking from conscience matters?
4. How does the gathering reflect shared values in the community?
5. How do others respond to the girls' choices?
6. What do the girls begin to understand about how ideas spread?

7. How does the ending show that their journey is continuing?